SAINT MICHAEL COLLEGE OF CARAGA

RURAL TOURISM DEVELOPMENT IN AGUSAN DEL NORTE

College of Tourism and Hospitality Management

A Thesis Proposal Presented To

The Faculty of

In Partial Requirements for the Degree

BACHELOR OF SCIENCE IN TOURISM MANAGEMENT

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MARCH 2026

CHAPTER 1

THE PROBLEM AND ITS SCOPE

1.1 Background of the study

Rural tourism has increasingly been recognized worldwide as a strategic approach to sustainable development, particularly in rural and countryside areas. Globally, it is promoted as a means of diversifying rural economies, generating employment, preserving cultural heritage, and encouraging environmental stewardship (Kazmina et al., 2021; García & López, 2024). As tourism demand shifts toward experiential, community-based, and environmentally responsible travel, rural destinations have gained prominence as viable alternatives to mass tourism (Cheer, 2024). In developing countries, rural tourism plays a critical role in addressing regional inequalities by providing livelihood opportunities for marginalized communities and stimulating local entrepreneurship. International studies show that rural tourism contributes to income generation, small enterprise development, and community empowerment when supported by effective governance and planning structures (Liu et al., 2023; Chen & Wang, 2023). However, these benefits are often uneven due to infrastructural and institutional limitations.

In the Philippine context, rural tourism has become an important component of national and regional development strategies, particularly under community-based and sustainable tourism initiatives promoted by the Department of Tourism (DOT, 2023). Provinces such as Bohol, Ifugao, and Surigao del Norte have demonstrated how rural tourism can support economic growth while strengthening cultural identity and environmental conservation (Bulilan, 2021; Supera et al., 2024). Nevertheless, several studies note that rural destinations in the country continue to

face challenges related to infrastructure, governance, and tourism planning, which constrain long-term sustainability (Dagdag, 2023; Caburatan et al., 2024). Within the Caraga Region, Agusan del Norte is emerging as a developing rural tourism destination, particularly in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Despite increasing tourist arrivals and expanding tourism activities, there is limited empirical research examining how rural tourism affects economic, socio-cultural, and ecological conditions in these municipalities. This lack of localized evidence highlights the need for focused research to support evidence-based planning and sustainable rural tourism development in Agusan del Norte.

International literature highlights the multidimensional contribution of rural tourism in achieving sustainable development. Economically, rural tourism has proved to contribute to the stimulation of local economies through job creation, diversification of income, and promotion of small-scale enterprises. Research studies conducted in Africa, Europe, and Asia indicate that rural tourism raises demand for rural products and services, which enhances the resilience of rural economies. Beyond economic impacts, rural tourism brings significant contributions to the conservation of cultural heritage and enhancement of community identity. Research evidence from rural communities in Asia and Europe shows that tourism renews traditional practices, local crafts, and indigenous knowledge in cases where communities are involved in the planning and management of tourism activities. For instance, Arifin & Sulistyo (2022) and Zhao et al. (2025) present evidence on how tourism rejuvenates traditions and local handicrafts, as well as indigenous knowledge. Additionally, rural tourism has been linked with enhanced social coherence and closer cooperation among residents. Sustainability and environmental considerations can also be identified as themes. Some research points out that ecotourism and CBTs favor conservation and raise environmental awareness as long as

touristic activities are well handled (Ardiansyah et al., 2023; Echeverri et al., 2024). Nonetheless, researchers note that environmental degradation can be provoked both through ecotourism and rural tourism as well, especially due to poor planning (Li et al., 2021; Shang et al., 2025). This information generally indicates that rural tourism must be well managed from both social and environmental points of view for optimal results.

Recent studies in the Philippines have also pointed out the positive impacts of rural tourism, underlining its role in generating income, biodiversity conservation, and social transformation. Yamagishi et al., (2021) stated that rural tourism has become an important global phenomenon, especially in the Philippines, where it is viewed as a potential driver of sustainable development, livelihood diversification, and the preservation of cultural and natural heritage. How people see a destination greatly influences their choices and is essential to trip planning (He & Ming, 2020). Understanding this connection helps explain tourist behavior, especially concerning Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) 8. This objective protects the environment and lessens inequality while fostering productive employment, decent work, and sustainable economic growth (United Nations, 2023). However, for this development to be sustainable and in line with the Sustainable Development Goals, effective policies with good economic, social, and cultural consequences must be implemented. Rural tourism has the potential to significantly benefit local economies and communities, but its success is dependent on proper planning and management (López-Sanz et al., 2021). According to Supera et al. (2024), there are advantages and disadvantages to rural tourism in Surigao del Norte. It helps improve the economy, culture, and environment, but still faces problems that need proper attention and solutions. Challenges such as limited infrastructure, access to finance, and capacity building need to be addressed to fully harness the potential of rural tourism in the country (You, 2022).

Within the Caraga Region, Agusan del Norte is emerging as a developing rural tourism destination, particularly in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen. Despite increasing tourist arrivals and expanding tourism activities, there is limited empirical research examining how rural tourism affects economic, socio-cultural, and ecological conditions in these municipalities. This lack of localized evidence highlights the need for focused research to support evidence-based planning and sustainable rural tourism development in Agusan del Norte. Although there is extensive literature on rural tourism in the Philippines, the existing body of empirical literature primarily focuses on identified tourist sites, such as Surigao del Norte, Bohol, and Ifugao, among others (Bulilan, 2021; Supera et al., 2024). Hence, this study still lacks significant empirical findings on the effects of rural tourist sites, specifically in Agusan del Norte, in relation to the economic, socio-cultural, as well as ecologic aspects.

Furthermore, very few studies employ a stakeholder approach where the views of all stakeholders, including tourists, residents, and businessmen in a rural area, have to be taken into consideration. The lack of localized study, particularly stakeholder-driven, affects the capacity of the concerned LGUs to be able to craft policies. It is important to help mitigate this challenge to be able to assess if the same set of problems that exist in other areas could be found in the areas of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.

This study will delve into how tourism contributes to rural development in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte. Specifically, the study will investigate the economic, socio-cultural, and ecological impacts brought about by rural tourism. It will also identify if challenges such as Infrastructural barriers, institutional barriers, and management and planning barriers exist, and its impact on the various stakeholders, which include tourists, community residents, and business operators. The findings of this study will be useful to a number of sectors. To the local government units and policymakers, the findings can provide the necessary basis for strategy formulation and the creation of programs that will enhance rural tourism and alleviate prevailing challenges. To the local communities and business operators, the study may provide insights into how they can maximize the economic and socio-cultural benefits from tourism while ensuring that environmental concerns are managed sustainably. Moreover, the findings can contribute to the College of Tourism and Hospitality Management by enriching its academic resources and providing locally grounded research that can be used for instruction, curriculum enhancement, and student engagement in evidence-based tourism practices. The study may also guide future extension activities and community-based tourism initiatives led by the college. The study can also serve as a reference for future studies on rural tourism development in other provinces. In general, this research aims to contribute to the development of a more inclusive, resilient, and sustainable rural tourism industry in Agusan del Norte, with concomitant benefits accruable both to the local populace and the wider regional economy.

1.2 Review of Related Literature

Rural tourism development has become an important focal point of contemporary research and policy discussions, particularly in developing countries, in which tourism is a key strategy for regional development and community empowerment. With many countries like the Philippines decentralizing tourism to achieve inclusive development, rural destinations are increasingly targeted for realizing desirable economic opportunities, strengthening socio-cultural identities, and guaranteeing environmental sustainability. However, while many studies acknowledge benefits from rural tourism, they also mention challenges impeding the realization of its full potential, such as incomplete infrastructure, poor stakeholder communication, and insufficient promotional efforts. Understanding these impacts and constraints is crucial in framing a strategy that will ensure that tourism growth stays sustainable and community-oriented. This review of related literature covers earlier studies on the economic, socio-cultural, and ecological impacts of rural tourism, as well as the challenges that impede its development, and thus provides the basis for evaluating prevailing conditions in Agusan del Norte.

Impacts of Rural Tourism Development

Economic Capital

Rural tourism serves as an essential driver of local economic development by generating income, creating employment, and supporting micro-entrepreneurial activities. Liu et al. (2023) asserted that rural tourism promotes community development primarily through economic expansion, which can transform rural livelihoods. Similarly, Chen and Wang (2023) found in their study of Jiwodu Village, China, that tourism created new income streams for rural families and encouraged small-scale business ventures, such as souvenir shops and local homestays.

García and López (2024) also revealed that in Spain's mountain regions, the growth of ecotourism increased household income by fostering small enterprises like guesthouses and guided tours. This mirrors Hassan, Abdelmoaty, and Salem's (2022) findings in Saudi Arabia, where tourism became a tool for financial empowerment, helping residents achieve economic stability through the establishment of small and medium enterprises (SMEs). These studies collectively emphasize that rural tourism does not only generate direct employment but also stimulates secondary industries like food supply, transportation, and handicraft production.

Moreover, Bautista and Ruiz (2023) highlighted that in Colombia, tourism encouraged residents to integrate cultural education into their economic activities, teaching younger generations traditional crafts while earning income from tourists. This form of "cultural entrepreneurship" demonstrates how economic and cultural benefits often overlap in rural tourism development.

In the Philippine setting, Bucoy et al. (2024) found that community-based tourism (CBT) in Zamboanga City significantly boosted family income and job availability, contributing to overall local economic resilience. Likewise, Bulilan (2021) observed that the active involvement of local government units (LGUs) in Bohol in managing tourism enterprises enabled communities to retain profits locally rather than depending solely on external investors. However, Dagdag (2023) pointed out that tourism's positive economic impact can on ly be sustained if supported by continuous visitor inflow, improved infrastructure, and consistent local participation.

In summary, these studies collectively confirm that rural tourism enhances economic capital by diversifying livelihoods, creating sustainable jobs, and empowering communities to participate in tourism-driven enterprises. However, as the literature cautions, these economic gains can only be maintained through strategic planning, adequate infrastructure, and inclusive governance that ensures all stakeholders benefit equally.

Sociocultural Capital

Beyond economic gains, rural tourism significantly contributes to strengthening community identity, social cohesion, and cultural preservation. Arifin

and Sulistyo (2022) demonstrated that in Indonesia, the participation of women in rural tourism revitalized traditional practices such as handicrafts and local cuisine, while simultaneously increasing family income. This empowerment of women played a key role in promoting inclusive development and sustaining community traditions. Similarly, Zhao, Liu, and Wang (2025) found that rural tourism in China enhanced cooperation and trust among residents by fostering a shared sense of purpose, particularly in communities that work collectively to manage tourism facilities.

Cordova-Buiza et al. (2025) emphasized that community participation in tourism decision-making strengthens residents' sense of ownership and pride. When locals are empowered to manage and benefit from tourism activities, they tend to preserve their cultural heritage more actively. Lekaota and Khashane (2025) further supported this idea, arguing that inclusivity in tourism planning fosters accountability and ensures that development aligns with community values and traditions.

In the Philippine context, Inocenio (2023) pointed out that in Biliran, active community involvement and strengthened communication with local tourism councils led to a greater understanding of tourism's long-term benefits. Jacot, Losenada, and Sacramento (2025) echoed this by suggesting that promoting "localized tourism" or "staycations" encourages residents to explore their own cultural assets and participate in local tourism projects. Likewise, Lo and Alejandro (2022) observed that community-based tourism (CBT) programs foster stronger interpersonal relationships, trust, and mutual respect, which enhance social harmony and cultural continuity.

Furthermore, Villamor (2024) explained that community support for tourism depends on how residents perceive its impacts on their social life, cultural identity, and environment. When people observe that tourism respects their heritage and improves their quality of life, they are more inclined to sustain it. Conversely, Catapang and Ylagan (2022) cautioned that unchecked commercialization may lead to cultural commodification and rising living costs, which can reduce community acceptance of tourism initiatives.

Therefore, the reviewed studies indicate that rural tourism strengthens sociocultural capital by empowering communities, preserving traditions, and fostering collaboration. However, it requires continuous dialogue between LGUs and residents to ensure that cultural authenticity is maintained while adapting to modernization and external influences.

Ecological Capital

Rural tourism also plays an essential role in environmental conservation and ecological awareness. Ardiansyah et al. (2023) argued that ecotourism initiatives can motivate local communities to engage in conservation practices, as they directly benefit from the protection of their natural surroundings. Similarly, García and López (2024) observed that in Spain's mountain regions, well-managed ecotourism helped protect fragile ecosystems while balancing tourism activities with conservation goals.

Li and Zhou (2021) found that although tourism around China's Wolong Nature Reserve improved residents' living conditions, it also created environmental strain, including waste and land degradation. This demonstrates the dual nature of tourism—

offering both opportunities and threats to ecosystems, depending on management practices. Echeverri et al. (2024) further noted that integrating natural and cultural heritage in tourism planning leads to a more holistic form of conservation that values both biodiversity and traditional knowledge systems.

In the Philippine context, Gutierrez (2022) and Gabileo (2021) documented that community-based ecotourism in El Nido and Bojo River encouraged local stewardship, such as mangrove reforestation and coastal clean-ups, balancing livelihood generation and environmental protection. Escamis (2024) observed a similar pattern in Marilog District, where tourism prompted residents to participate in waste management and tree-planting initiatives. Moreover, Asilum, Noveda, and Ybañez (2023) reported that in Masbate, rural tourism strengthened environmental awareness while simultaneously improving community solidarity.

However, Shang et al. (2025) cautioned that increasing tourist numbers may lead to pollution, habitat disruption, and resource depletion if not managed sustainably. They recommended that local governments establish clear environmental policies and regular monitoring systems to mitigate ecological risks.

Taken together, these studies show that rural tourism enhances ecological capital when it integrates environmental conservation into tourism planning. The findings suggest that sustainable rural tourism should not only generate income but also safeguard the natural assets that attract visitors in the first place. For provinces like Agusan del Norte, strengthening environmental governance and community

participation is key to ensuring that tourism supports both ecological sustainability and rural livelihood development.

Infrastructural Barriers

Several studies have highlighted that inadequate infrastructure is one of the primary barriers to rural tourism growth. According to Kazmina et al. (2021), the development of rural tourism in Russia's Rostov region heavily depends on reliable infrastructure such as road networks, transportation facilities, and utilities. They found that while rural areas have rich cultural and natural attractions, the lack of accessibility limits both visitor arrivals and investment opportunities. Cheer (2024) similarly emphasized that sustainable countryside tourism requires sufficient infrastructure that supports mobility, accommodation, and communication, arguing that tourists are less likely to visit destinations that lack convenience and safety

Moreover, according to the World Tourism Organization (2023), this infrastructure gap was rated as the first challenge facing rural tourism, since a lack of proper roads, ports, airports, and digital connectivity leads to inadequate visitor arrivals and ultimately reduces investment opportunities. Ariyani and Fauzi (2023) studied sustainable rural tourism in Central Java, Indonesia, and stressed the important role of proper infrastructure and amenities; on the other hand, ICT and communication technology are crucial for the support of both tourists and local communities.

In the Philippine setting, Dagdag (2023) noted that most of the tourism destinations in the countryside suffer from poor road conditions, limited transportation systems, and a lack of amenities that would turn off both domestic and

international tourists. Caburatan et al. (2024) further expounded on this issue by saying that inadequate facilities, such as rest stops, proper sanitation, and available hotels, weaken visitor satisfaction and prevent the growth of local businesses. Ambunan Mendoza (2022) confirmed these findings in farm-based tourism sites in Cavite, where stakeholders cited poor infrastructure and a lack of amenities as crucial hindrances to sustainable tourism development. The Department of Tourism (2023) also recognized infrastructure development as part of the Regional Tourism Development Plan for the Caraga Region, saying that some areas in Agusan del Norte are still unvisited due to poor road conditions and a lack of transportation options.

Kazmina et al. (2021) and Dagdag (2023) agreed that the private sector is hesitant to invest in rural destinations where infrastructure is lacking, creating a cycle of underdevelopment. Cheer (2024) warned that while promoting tourism can indeed generate economic gains, these are not sustainable if unsupported by proper infrastructure and maintenance. Al Matris (2023) added that often, a lack of adequate infrastructure interacts with issues of marketing and lack of resources, which make such destinations uncompetitive and diminish their capacity to attract not only tourists but also investors. Improvement of roads, communication systems, and public facilities remains crucial for enabling local communities to take part in tourism activities.

These infrastructural barriers are identified within the literature as inhibiting rural tourism development by constraining access and investments while reducing visitor satisfaction. Such a challenge, however, calls for the LGUs to work with national agencies and also private stakeholders to ensure that rural areas, such as Agusan del

Norte, optimize their full potentials in tourism.

Institutional Barriers

These institutional barriers refer to various administrative and policy-related problems that make it difficult for rural tourism governance to be effective. Campos, Apdohan, and Enyart (2021) reported that although Agusan del Sur is an area with high environmental and tourism potential, weak coordination among LGUs and national agencies limited the efficiency of tourism development. In a related finding, Dela Peña et al. (2022) noted that during the management of Mt. Magdiwata Forest Reserve, overlapping mandates, lack of cooperation, and limited policy enforcement hampered sustainable tourism management.

As corroborated by Madrid (2024), institutional effectiveness is grounded on effective communication linkages between and among LGUs, local communities, and private stakeholders. For want of this linkage, most rural tourism projects wind up with delayed implementation, multiple and divisive leadership, and poor accountability. Hilvano et al. (2024) found that when LGUs engage the community in planning and policy-making, tourism development became more integrated and inclusive. They cited that in participatory governance, transparency and shared responsibility pave the path toward long-term sustainability of tourism.

Similarly, Ariyani and Fauzi (2023) pointed out that overcoming the challenges of governance in rural tourism requires institutional capacity, clear regulatory frameworks, and structured communications among stakeholders. Supera et al. (2024) noted that in Surigao del Norte, the lack of integrated institutional approaches resulted in inconsistent tourism branding and a lax coordination of marketing efforts

across municipalities. These findings reflect those of Campos et al. (2021), who indicated that institutional weaknesses—such as limited tourism policies, lack of trained personnel, and undefined governance structures—hinder the development of rural tourism.

Therefore, poor interagency coordination, low policymaking capacity, and lack of collaboration with the local communities are the institutional barriers in Agusan del Norte. For efficient governance and equitable distribution of tourism benefits among stakeholders, strengthening of institutional linkages and capacity-building initiatives within the tourism sector should be carried out.

Management and Planning Barriers

Beyond policy and infrastructure issues, the lack of proper management and planning remains a serious hindrance to rural tourism development. As indicated by Dagdag (2023), rural areas in most parts of the Philippines depend on organic tourism growth instead of adopting appropriate planning mechanisms. In such cases, visitation management usually becomes irregular, and destination branding is weak. This reactive approach results in short-lived projects with minimal long-term impact.

For instance, Campos et al. (2021) and Madrid (2024) insisted that most tourism programs without concrete management plans lack monitoring mechanisms that ensure efficient implementation and proper evaluation of the programs. Similarly, Supera et al. (2024) showed that in Surigao del Norte, limited management capacity combined with weak marketing systems resulted in less competitiveness compared to more developed destinations. Al Matris (2023) further underlined that management and planning gaps-like lack of financial management, marketing strategy, and

monitoring framework-directly impinge upon the sustainability and competitiveness of rural destinations.

Similarly, Caburatan et al. (2024) stated that long-term strategies regarding environmental conservation, maintenance of infrastructure, and educating the community are all integral in sustainable rural tourism. Ambunan Mendoza (2022) said that the inability to plan well leads to the underutilization of resources and failure in realizing involvement opportunities. Hilvano et al. (2024) have also presented that deficiencies in planning lead to misallocations because tourism initiatives are usually done without any clear objectives and stated measures of outcomes. There are management and planning barriers in Agusan del Norte: a shortage of technical expertise in tourism officers, the lack of long-term development frameworks, and non-integrated marketing and monitoring systems. Such mismatches can be solved by strategic capacity building, planning using data, and stakeholder involvement to enhance the management of tourism for sustainable development of rural areas.

Collectively, the literature underlines the fact that the development of rural tourism faces three interconnected barriers: infrastructural, institutional, and management and planning. Poor infrastructure reduces accessibility and investment, weak institutions result in fragmented gov ernance, and ineffective management and planning hinders sustainability. Studies from 2021 to 2024, such as Al Matris (2023), Ariyani and Fauzi (2023), Ambunan Mendoza (2022), and UNWTO (2023), highly stressed the need for integrated planning, strong institutional cooperation, and inclusive local governance in overcoming these challenges. In the case of Agusan del Norte, collaborative policy measures, continuous training, and infrastructure

investment would help in addressing these issues to bring about a more resilient and competitive rural tourism sector.

The current literature on the development of rural tourism has found a clear pattern. While the benefits of rural tourism are both economic and socio-culturally significant and offer environmental as well as other benefits, these are possibly faced with development challenges. The current study has found that a possible issue within a number of existing research developments is a lack of infrastructure or development planning. Despite the challenges faced being different, a number of existing developments indicate that a favorable development environment is required for a number of benefits to be achieved. The current study will offer a significant observation concerning impacts and challenges since it gauges both simultaneously.

Age

Age is considered a major determinant of participation, perception, and behavior in rural tourism development. It thus affects the travel preferences, motivations, and propensity to participate in or enjoy any tourism-related activities. Indeed, Mureșan et al. (2021) found that the predominant age for rural tourists in mountain regions of Romania is 20–39 years, which reflects younger generations being more attracted to experiential and nature-based tourism. Younger tourists are often motivated by searching for adventure, exploring cultural experiences, and opportunities offered by social media. The comfort of staying, authenticity of culture, and traditional practices are often key interests for older tourists (Chan, 2023).

Age also influences the perspective of locals and other stakeholders.

Koutsouris et al. (2022) reported that Greek rural residents over 40 years old focus on tourism as a tool for maintaining culture and enhancing community identity, whereas younger respondents focus on economic benefits and modernization. Similarly, Dagdag (2023), in the Philippine context, noted that older residents often assume advisory roles in tourism councils, while younger residents lead operations such as tour guiding, event management, and digital marketing. These intergenerational differences suggest that tourism programs in Agusan del Norte should consider traditional knowledge from older residents along with innovative ideas of young stakeholders for inclusive and sustainable rural tourism development.

Sex/Gender

Gender influences participation, leadership, and perception in rural tourism. Despite the high value ascribed to women's roles in the literature for cultural preservation and service provision, men play an equally critical role in business management, infrastructure development, and policy implementation. López-Sanz et al. (2021) noticed that male owners were dominant in La Palma, Spain, before the COVID-19 pandemic, 56.5%, and continued to have a heavy presence in the management and operation levels after the pandemic, with 45.7%. In most cases, men are in charge of strategic decisions, financial planning, and technical management, thus providing stability and long-term sustainability for rural tourism businesses.

Meanwhile, women also contribute a great deal through service delivery, cultural programming, and community engagement (Arifin & Sulistyo, 2022). In the Philippines, Bucoy et al. (2024) found that men tend to take responsibility for business management and handling operations concerning infrastructure, while women

provide homestays, cultural tours, and other events within the community. Bulilan (2021) further documented that men often hold decision-making positions in local tourism councils, specifically for discussions involving economic or policy matters, while women are instrumental in community cohesion and maintaining cultural continuity. There is thus a need to understand the roles played by both men and women for gender-inclusive policies aimed at balancing leadership, service provision, and cultural preservation in rural tourism in Agusan del Norte.

Local and Foreign tourists

Tourists represent the primary demand side of rural tourism and are critical for economic sustainability. Demographic characteristics such as age, sex, and origin shape their travel behavior, preferences, and spending patterns. RSIS International (2024) reported that local tourists constitute the majority of visitors in Banaue, Ifugao, while foreign tourists stay longer and spend more, contributing substantially to the local economy. Younger tourists tend to seek adventure and immersive cultural experiences, whereas older tourists prioritize relaxation and authentic cultural engagement (Mureșan et al., 2021). Gender also plays a role; studies show that female tourists often prioritize safety, accessibility, and cultural experiences, whereas male tourists may emphasize adventure and exploration (Chan, 2023). Understanding the demographic profile of tourists helps local tourism planners in Agusan del Norte design products, services, and marketing strategies tailored to different age, gender, and nationality groups.

Community Residents

Residents are the heart of any rural tourism development, providing cultural

knowledge, labor, and supporting local governance. Perceptions on the impacts of tourism and willingness to participate in tourism activities may vary with age, gender, and socio-economic backgrounds. For instance, Koutsouris et al. (2022) pointed out that older residents tend to give more emphasis to cultural heritage preservation and environmental protection, while younger residents place a greater emphasis on livelihood opportunities and economic growth. Regarding gender, men generally become actively involved in decision-making processes, infrastructure development, and economic planning, while women engage in cultural activities, tourism services, and community outreach (Bulilan, 2021; Arifin & Sulistyo, 2022). Such demographic distinctions in the composition of residents influence residents' views and determine the inclusivity of any tourism initiative. Analyzing the demographics of its residents can thus help LGUs and tourism councils in Agusan del Norte identify which groups are underrepresented and formulate programs for inviting equitable participation across age and gender groups.

Business Operators

The business operators provide the necessary side of rural tourism with their accommodations, food services, tours, and cultural programming. Their demographic features, such as age, sex, and experience, affect their strategies, innovation capacity, and ability to link up with other stakeholders. López-Sanz et al. (2021) note that male operators often dominate management, oversee financial planning, and coordinate infrastructure development, while female operators contribute to service quality, customer experience, and cultural interpretation. Age also affects how the businesses are run: for example, younger operators may be more interested in modern marketing

and digital platforms, while older operators may have traditional approaches and long-standing experience. In the Philippines, Bulilan (2021) noted that a mix of young male and old male operators and service-oriented women entrepreneurs boosts economic performance and cultural authenticity. Such an understanding of demographic elements is important in crafting capacity-building programs, investment strategies, and collaborative networks among business operators in Agusan del Norte.

1.3 Theoretical Framework

The theoretical basis of this study is the Triple Bottom Line Theory. According to Elkington's TBL framework, proposed in 1994. The theory argues that sustainable development should encompass the following three areas: people, the planet, and profits. In other words, development efforts such as rural tourism development should not prioritize making profits beyond the benefits they should render to society.

In the case of this study, the economic aspect of the TBL matrix is analogous to the economic capital, which is quantified on the basis of indicators such as the creation of employment, income generation, growth of businesses, and opportunities for investment, which can be derived from the aspect of rural tourism. The other aspect, which is the social aspect, is comparable to the sociocultural capital, which encompasses indicators such as the enhancement of cultural conservation, community cohesion, social interaction, as well as the perception of the community in relation to the issue of tourism.

Moreover, the TBL model also serves as a tool to determine the challenges faced by the sustainability of rural tourism. Infrastructural barriers, institutional barriers,

and barriers to the management planning process are perceived to be obstacles which may jeopardize the integration of economic, social, and environment outcomes. Through the use of the TBL approach, this research focuses systematically on the convergence of the impacts and barriers within the context of the rural destinations of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.

Schematic Diagram

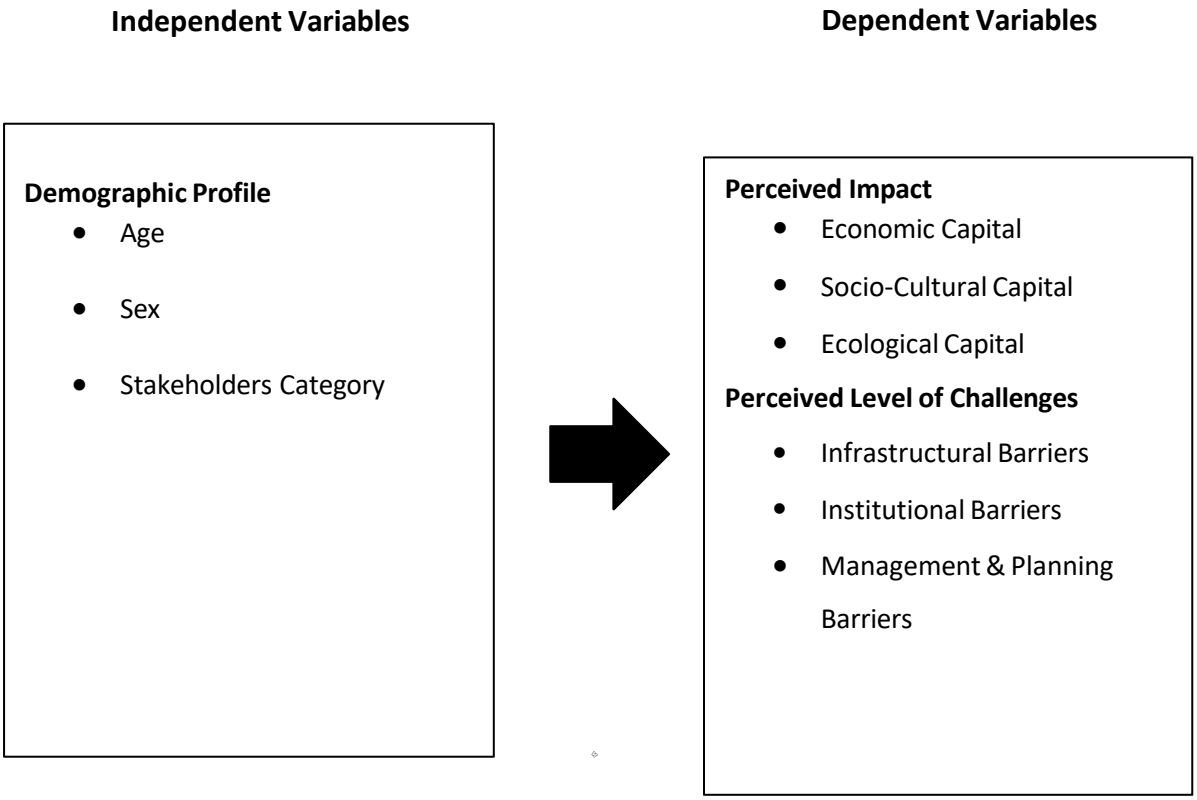


Figure 1. Research Framework of the Study

1.4 Statement of the Problem/ Objectives of the Study

1. What is the respondents profile in terms of ;
   1.1 Age;
   1.2 Sex;
   1.3 Stakeholders category?

2. What is the perceived impact of Rural Tourism Development in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte in terms of;
   2.1 Economic Capital;
   2.2 Socio-cultural Capital;
   2.3 Ecological Capital?

3. What is the perceived challenges in Rural Tourism Development in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte in terms of;
   3.1 Infrastructural Barrier;
   3.2 Institutional Barriers;
   3.3 Management and Planning Barrier?

4. Is there a significant relationship between perceived impact and perceived challenges in Rural Tourism Development in Agusan del Norte?

1.5 Hypothesis

(H_o) There is no significant relationship between the perceived impact and the perceived challenges in rural tourism development in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen Agusan del Norte.

(H_1) There is a significant relationship between the perceived impact and perceived challenges in rural tourism development in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen Agusan del Norte.

1.6 Scope and Delimitation

This study will focus on rural tourism development in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte. It aims to examine the perceived impacts of rural tourism and the challenges that influence its growth and sustainability. Specifically, the study investigates the economic, socio-cultural, and ecological impacts of rural tourism. Economic impacts include income generation, job creation, and business opportunities, while socio-cultural impacts involve cultural preservation, community identity, and social cohesion. Ecological impacts focus on environmental awareness, conservation practices, and the sustainable use of natural resources.

In addition, the study addresses the challenges to rural tourism development, which are categorized into infrastructural barriers, institutional barriers, and management and planning barriers. Infrastructural barriers include underdeveloped roads, limited transportation options, inadequate facilities, and poor communication systems that restrict tourist access and participation. Institutional barriers pertain to weak governance, limited coordination among local government units and agencies, unclear policies, and insufficient collaboration with stakeholders. Management and planning barriers cover deficiencies in strategic planning, marketing, monitoring, and

resource management that affect the sustainability and competitiveness of rural tourism.

The study will be considering the perspectives of three key stakeholder groups, local and foreign tourists, community residents, and business operators, in order to provide a comprehensive understanding of the impacts and challenges. However, the study will be limited to the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte and will not include other areas in the province or region. It will focus on perceived impacts and challenges rather than actual economic or ecological measurements. Other potential stakeholders, such as external government agencies, NGOs, or academic institutions, will be not included. Furthermore, challenges outside the scope of infrastructure, institutional governance, and management and planning, such as climate change or health crises, will be not considered. Data collection will be based on survey instruments capturing stakeholder perceptions, meaning the findings will reflect subjective viewpoints rather than purely objective measurements.

1.8 Definition of Terms

Age. Refers to the different age groups of people involved in rural tourism, such as young adults, middle-aged adults, and older adults. Age helps determine how people view the effects of tourism in Agusan del Norte.

Business Operators. Referes to individuals or organizations that run tourism businesses, such as resorts, restaurants, souvenir shops, and transport services in Buenavista, Nasipit, and

Carmen. Moreover, they provide services, create jobs, and support rural tourism development.

Community Residents. Refers to residents in the study areas who are affected by tourism. They may be tied to tourism, join cultural activities, or run local businesses. Their support is essential for sustainable and inclusive tourism.

Ecological Capital. Refers to the environmental benefits of tourism, including conserving natural resources, protecting wildlife, and using eco-friendly practices.

Economic Capital. Refers to the economic advantages of tourism, such as revenue, employment, company expansion, and support for the local economy.

Infrastructural Barriers. Refers to physical and technological facility limitations that hold back the development of rural tourism.

Institutional barriers. Refers to issues involved in governance, policies, and administration that have an impact on the effective management of rural tourism.

Management and Planning Barriers.Refers to deficiencies or weaknesses in tourism management and development planning that are barriers to sustainable growth.

Perceived Challenges. Refers to issues or obstacles, like inadequate infrastructure, a lack of communication among stakeholders, and insufficient marketing, impacting rural tourism.

Perceived Impact. Refers to how local stakeholders (such as residents, business owners, tourists) view the effects or benefits of rural tourism in their area across economic, sociocultural, and environmental aspects.

Rural Tourism Development. Refers to tourism activities that take place in non-urban areas, often focused on nature, agriculture, culture, and community-based experiences. In this study, it refers explicitly to tourism activities in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen in Agusan del Norte.

Sex/Gender. Refers to the classification of people as male or female. It shows differences in participation, roles, and perceptions in tourism activities and community programs.

Sociocultural Capital. Refers to social and cultural benefits or effects of tourism, such as preservation of traditions, enhancement of community identity, cultural exchange, and involvement of residents in tourism.

Stakeholders. Refers to individuals or groups directly or indirectly involved or affected by rural tourism activities. This includes tourists, community members, and business owners.

Sustainable Tourism. Refers to a form of tourism that meets the needs of present tourists and host regions while protecting and enhancing opportunities for the future, with minimal impact on the environment and local culture.

Tourists (Local/Foreign). Refers to individuals who travel to rural destinations in Agusan del Norte either from within the Philippines (local tourists) or from other countries (foreign tourists). They engage in leisure, cultural, or nature-based activities that contribute to the local economy and the overall growth of rural tourism.

Triple Bottom Line (TBL) Theory. Refers to a sustainability framework that emphasizes balancing three core elements—economic prosperity, social well-being, and environmental responsibility—in evaluating the overall success of development

activities, including tourism.

CHAPTER 2

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This chapter will discuss the research design, research locale, research respondents, and research instrument used in the study. It also explains the ethical standards, data gathering procedure, and statistical treatment involved.

2.1 Research Design

This study will be utilizing a descriptive quantitative research design to determine the perceived impact and perceived level of challenges with the rural tourism development in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. Descriptive design systematically collects and analyzes numerical data to describe the characteristics of a population or phenomenon without manipulating variables, therefore, it will describe existing conditio ns and interpret the relationship between variables. Quantitative design will be applied to collect measurable data's gathered through a structured survey questionnaire that will be analyzing different ideas from the respondents of the classified stakeholders.

Surveys of tourist, locals, and business owners will be used to gather data. This approach is appropriate since it enables the researchers to collect and examine viewpoints from various groups. The survey questionnaire was adapted from the study Rural Tourism Development in the Philippines by Supera et al. (2024) and Investigating the Factors Hampering Rural Tourism Development in Target Tourism Rural of West Azerbaijan Province, Iran by Goudarzi et al. (2014)

2.2 Research Locale

This study will be conducted in Buenavista, Nasipit, Carmen, and Agusan del Norte. The respondents will specifically include tourists, business operators, and community residents.

These municipalities have much potential for rural tourism because of their natural resources, cultural heritage, and local attractions. In addition to producing rice, bananas, and cacao, Buenavista is also growing its bamboo industry. Nasipit is growing as a tourism center with ecotourism, agri-tourism, and extreme sports, while also serving as a hub for agriculture and industry in the Caraga Region. Carmen has large mango plantations, beach resorts, and scuba diving sites, supporting a thriving ecotourism sector.

These areas show that rural tourism can provide income and create livelihood opportunities for local communities. The survey instrument used in this study is designed to measure rural tourism's perceived impacts and challenges to the local communities in these municipalities.

2.3 Research Environment, population, and sample

The study will focus on tourists, business operators, and community residents in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte. The data was provided through a formal request letter to the LGU Tourism Offices requesting the list of registered business establishments in the said municipalities. Based on the data

provided, there are a total of 20,561 tourist visits from January to July of the year 2025 in the selected tourist resorts in Agusan del Norte namely, Mars Cottages**,** Donabelle Cottages, Aldas Beach Resort, Pamela Beach Resort, and Cembrano Beach Resort in the Municipality of Buenavista. While in the Municipality of Nasipit are Felias Beach Resort, **Amontay Beach** Resort, Mantallo View Resthouse, Lariosa Place, Olaivar Beach Resort. Lastly, Bolihon Cove, **Vina4 Blu Waters Bach Resort,** Mahigalaon Beach Resort, Mt. Camel View Park ,and Kimberrey Beach Resort for the Municipality of Carmen. From this population, a total of 1,028 tourist respondents will be chosen through convenience sampling. Meanwhile, there are a total of 129,283 community residents from Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, a total of 1,142 locals will be chosen as respondents for the community residents category. Finally, respondents for the business operators category will be the chosen five tourist destinations in each municipality, a total of one (1) staff per tourist destination will be chosen through convenience sampling. To ensure appropriate representation, the inclusion of tourist sites was not limited solely to the most visited establishments. The study also considered destinations based on the nature of the tourism attraction, such as beach resorts, eco-spots, scenic viewpoints, and nature-based accommodations

`Buenavista		Total	SAMPLE	PERCENTAGE
1.	Mars Cottages	1,647.0	82	8.01
2.	Donabelle Cottages	1,377.0	69	6.70
3.	Aidas Beach Resort	1,609.0	80	7.83
4.	Pamela Beach Resort	1,242.0	62	6.04
5.	Cembrano Beach Resort	1,020.0	51	4.96
Nasipit				
1.	Felias Beach Resort	1,360.0	68	6.61
2.	Amontay Beach Resort	486.0	24	2.36
3.	Mantalio View Resthouse	454.0	23	2.21
4.	Lariosa Place	453.0		
5.	Olaivar Beach Resort	473.0	24	2.30
Carmen				
1.Bolihon Cove		3,625.0	181	17.63
2.	Vin4 Blue Waters Beach Resort	3,686.0	184	17.93
3.Mahigalaon Beach Resort		2,060.0	103	10.02
4.Mt.Carmel View Park		672.0	34	3.27
5.Kimberry Beach Resort		592.0	30	2.88
Total		**20,561.0**	**1,028**	**100.00**

Table 1 shows the distribution of respondents involved in the study. ***Specifically, the toursits (local/foreign) and business operators of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte***

Table 2. Respondents of the study

	Total	Sample	Percentage
Buenavista	70,691	383	33.5
Nasipit	36,968	381	33.4
Carmen	21,624	378	33.1
Total	**129,283**	**1,142**	**100.0**

Table 2 shows the distribution of respondents involved in the study. ***Specifically, the community residents of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.***

2.4 Research Data and Analysis Plan

Research Instrument

This study will use two adapted survey questionnaires in relation to the two variables in this framework. For the impact on economic, socio-cultural, and ecological capital, a survey questionnaire will be adapted based on the study *Rural Tourism Development in the Philippines* by Supera et al. (2024), published in the Journal of Economics, Finance and Management Studies will be used. Changes were made to make it suitable for Filipino respondents. (Supera et al, 2024). Moreover, for the challenges in infrastructural, institutional, management & planning barrier, an adapted survey questionnaire from the study *Investigating the Factors Hampering Rural Tourism Development in Target Tourism Rural of West Azerbaijan Province, Iran* published on Vol. II, Issue 7, 2014 by Goudarzi et al. (2014) will be used. The researchers will be sending a formal letter to the authors upon requesting to adapt the research instruments.

There will be three sections to the questionnaire. The profiles of the respondents, including their age, sex, and stakeholder category (tourists, business owners, and locals, will be included in Part I. The perceived economic, sociocultural, and ecological effects of rural tourism in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen are measured in Part II. Part III examines the perceived challenges in the same municipalities concerning their infrastructural, institutional, management & planning barrier. Supera et al., (2024) study were tested using Cronbach's alpha, the consistency and reliability of the questionnaire results showed a value of 0.785, which is suitable for the study. Likewise, Goudarzi et al., (2014) study Cronbach's alpha were analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistics such as: Eta-test, U-test and Pathanalysis, resulted scales were above 0.7. ata. Each section will contain statements rated using a five-point Likert scale, ranging from 5 (Strongly Agree) to 1(Strongly Disagree). The collected data will be analyzed using descriptive and inferential statistical methods to determine the relationship between the perceived impact and challenges of the rural tourism development in Agusan del Norte, in accordance with the framework established by Supera et al. (2024) and Goudarzi et al. (2014).

2.5 Research Ethical Standards

A. Intellectual Property Rights.

The study respects intellectual property by keeping respondents anonymous. All sources, including books, articles, and data, are properly cited to give credit to the original authors while protecting the researcher's work.

B. Informed Consent.

The respondents include tourists, business operators, and residents of the Buenavista, Nasipit, Carmen, and Agusan del Norte communities. Before participating, the researchers will orient the respondents and explain the study's purpose, benefits, and possible risks. Respondents will be informed that they can withdraw from the study without explaining. A written consent form will be provided to ensure they fully understand their rights.

C. Data Privacy and Confidentiality.

Respondents' demographic data and all other personal information will be kept private and used only with informed consent. To safeguard identities, data will be anonymize. To protect privacy, the researchers will oversee the administration of the questionnaires. The code that connects participant responses will only be accessible by the researchers. All information gathered will be handled securely throughout the study to preserve the participants' privacy.

D. Voluntary Participation and Freedom to Withdraw.

Participation in this study is voluntary. Respondents will be informed that they can withdraw without any negative consequences. This study does not involve animals, so alternatives to animal use are not applicable.

E. Minimization of Harm and Risk Management

To establish a secure environment, researchers will engage with respondents courteously and professionally. Respondents can be directed to support services like the guidance office or clinic if there are any risks. Following participation, a debriefing session will be offered to ensure no emotional, psychological, or physical harm. Since animals are not used in this study, the 3Rs—replacement, reduction, and refinement—do not apply.

F. Beneficence and Contribution to Knowledge.

This study aims to better understand the perceived impact and challenges of rural tourism development in Agusan del Norte. Survey findings will be available to respondents upon request. Based on the results, the study's benefits focus on improving rural tourism programs.

G. Justice and Fair Participant Selection

In order to meet the goals of the study, respondents will be equitably chosen based on well-defined inclusion criteria. There will be no discrimination against participants from diverse backgrounds.

H. Data Integrity and Accuracy.

Data will be gathered and examined using accepted techniques to guarantee accuracy and dependability. Researchers will ask the local government units of Buenavista, Nasipit, Carmen, and Agusan del Norte for a comprehensive list of

qualified responders. Every finding will be thoroughly examined to avoid bias or mistakes and ensure accurate results.

I. Transparency and Honesty in Reporting.

The study results will be presented truthfully, without data manipulation or alteration. To uphold ethical research standards and respect intellectual property rights, all sources—including scholarly references—will be cited appropriately. No conflicts of interest exist, and specific AI tools may support the research.

J. Use of Patented or Copyrighted Materials.

The study will not use any patented materials. All references and other copyrighted content will be appropriately cited in accordance with intellectual property laws. By doing this, plagiarism is prevented and academic integrity is guaranteed.

K. Considerations for Animal Human Trials.

Respondents will be given an informed consent form and information about the study's potential risks and benefits. If any physical, psychological, or emotional risks materialize, appropriate health monitoring and support services will be accessible.

L. Responsible Use of AI and Related Technology.

The researchers will use digital tools to support the study, ensuring accuracy and reliability. AI tools like ChatGPT will help summarize statements and improve clar ty. Platforms like Google Scholar, Elicit, and Typeset.io will be used to find reliable supporting studies. Grammarly will be used to maintain proper grammar and readability. All technologies will be used responsibly to protect the integrity of the research.

M. Ethical Clearance and Institutional Approval.

The Institutional Review Board of Saint Michael College of Caraga will obtain ethical approval. This ensures the study follows all guidelines for protecting respondents, maintaining data privacy, and respecting intellectual property rights.

2.6 Data Gathering Procedure

In gathering the data, the researchers sent a request letter to the Municipal Tourism Office of the Local Government Unit of the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, which was verified by the CTHM dean, to obtain the complete list of respondents for the study. This list was then forwarded to the statistician to ensure the population remained consistent. After this is confirmed, the researchers will use a research tool that was extracted from June 2024 issue of the Journal of Economics, Finance, and Management Studies article titled *Rural Tourism Development in the Philippine*s by Supera et al. (2024) and Vol. II, Issue 7, 2014

titled *Investigating the Factors Hampering Rural Tourism Development in Target Tourism Rural of West Azerbaijan Province, Iran* by Goudarzi et al. (2014). It will be the primary tool used to collect the data. The researchers will request permission to perform the study by sending the CTHM dean an approved letter. In order to achieve the results, the researchers will disseminate the survey questionnaire and collect the data after obtaining approval. Once the data has been gathered, the researchers will aggregate the questionnaire responses and send the arranged data to a statistician for reliability and accuracy checks. Once the statistician provides the finalized data, the researchers will analyze, interpret, and discuss the findings.

2.7 Data Analysis Plan

Frequency and Percentage—Descri be the respondents' profile, including age, sex, and type of stakeholder.

Weighted Mean—To measure how respondents view the impact and challenges of rural tourism in Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte, regarding the economy, society, and environment.

Pearson's r Correlation – To find the relationship between the perceived impact and the perceived challenges of rural tourism in the municipalities of Buenavista, Nasipit, and Carmen, Agusan del Norte.

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